Lesson 10: Grammar: Phrasal Verbs

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 3.4: Grammar Presentation-Phrasal Verbs; 3.5: Applying Grammar to Reading; 3.6: Communication Practice; Phrasal Verbs.

In this lesson

You will learn what phrasal verbs are, the difference between separable and inseparable phrasal verbs, where to put a pronoun object, and how one phrasal verb can have several meanings. You will also find phrasal verbs in "The Value of Confusion". Lecturers use them all the time, so they help you follow your classes.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a phrasal verb is and give the meaning of common ones.
- Put a noun or pronoun object in the correct place with a separable phrasal verb (gave it up, not "gave up it").
- Keep an inseparable phrasal verb together (keep up with it).
- Choose the correct meaning of a phrasal verb with several meanings from its context.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
phrasal verb	a verb + a small word (up, off, out, down, on ...) with one meaning	put off = delay or postpone
separable	a noun or pronoun can go between the verb and the small word	I look the new word up in the dictionary.
inseparable	the words must stay together	I look up to my grandmother.
object	the noun or pronoun that receives the action	Hyun-Ki gave up smoking.
object pronoun	it, them, him, her, me, us, you	Hyun-Ki gave it up.
transitive	can have an object	The teacher is trying to keep up with it.
intransitive	has no object	My car broke down.
three-word phrasal verb	a verb + two small words; most cannot be separated	keep up with, put up with

Rules and explanations

What is a phrasal verb?

- A verb followed by a small word (the book calls it a preposition) that together form one meaning: put off = delay or postpone. The meaning is often different from the meanings of the two words, so learn each one like a new word.
- Two kinds: I looked up the new word in the dictionary. / I look the new word up in the dictionary. (separable: kept together or separated) I look up to my grandmother. (inseparable)

Separable phrasal verbs

Pattern	Example	
verb + small word + noun	Hyun-Ki gave up smoking.	correct
verb + noun + small word	Hyun-Ki gave smoking up.	correct
verb + pronoun + small word	Hyun-Ki gave it up.	correct
verb + small word + pronoun	Hyun-Ki gave up it.	WRONG

- A noun can go in either place. A pronoun (it, them, him, her) must go between the two words.
- A few must always be separated: ask over (invite) and call back (return a phone call).
- Examples: bring up (bring attention to), call off (cancel), carry out (implement), find out (learn new information), leave out (exclude), let down (disappoint), put off (postpone), take off (remove). Full list: Table 11 in the lesson material.

Inseparable phrasal verbs

- They must stay together, and a noun or a pronoun comes after them: The teacher is trying to keep up with grading the homework. The teacher is trying to keep up with it.
- Tip: most three-word phrasal verbs cannot be separated.
- Examples: carry on (continue), get over (recover), go over (review), keep up with (maintain pace), look after (care for), put up with (tolerate), stand for (represent), take after (resemble). Full list: Table 12 in the lesson material.

Phrasal verbs with multiple meanings

The same words can have several meanings. They can be separable with one meaning and inseparable with another, or transitive with one meaning and intransitive with another: My car broke down (no object). The teacher broke down the math problem (object). The book's examples are in Table 13 in the lesson material. Meanings for Exercise 9:

- **work out:** a) exercise b) solve a problem
- **pick up:** a) lift something b) give someone a ride c) learn a new skill d) buy something at the store e) notice something; detect f) start again g) improve
- **turn down:** a) reduce intensity b) reject an offer or request
- **make up:** a) invent b) compose c) no longer be upset d) compensate for a lack of something

- **make out:** a) be able to identify or see with great effort b) write details on a check c) kiss in a sexual way
- **look up:** a) search b) improve c) admire
- **cut off:** a) remove something b) stop the supply of something c) interrupt someone d) cause disconnection of a phone or internet
- **go out:** a) leave your home b) stop burning

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic has no phrasal verbs like give up or put off, and their meaning usually cannot be guessed from the two words. Learn each one with its meaning and an example sentence, as in the book's tables.

Practice

Exercise 3. Pronoun objects (separable). Rewrite each sentence with a pronoun. Example: Sadie always leaves out her youngest cousin, Alyssa. = Sadie always leaves her out.

1. Wei forgot to give back the money.
2. Joan wants to ask Jacobo over for lunch.
3. The teacher broke down the grammar rule so that students could better understand the process.
4. Please fill up my thermos with coffee. I'm tired!
5. We need to help out the team members because they are struggling to complete the project.
6. My children hate to pick up their laundry.
7. The nurse told Paolo to take off his shirt.
8. Have you called your friends back?
9. Sometimes children hang up the phone prematurely.
10. It's not efficient to have the light on during the day. Please turn off the light.

Exercise 4. Separable phrasal verbs: meaning. Choose the most appropriate phrasal verb. (In the lesson material the last three items are numbered 8, 8 and 9 by mistake; here they are 8, 9 and 10, as in the book's answer key.)

1. My sister _____ the meeting when she came down with the flu. a) picked up b) carried out c) called off d) fixed up
2. After having the flu, she had to _____ her appetite slowly. a) fill out b) pass down c) find out d) build up
3. Sylvie _____ the house before her friends came over. a) fixed up b) helped out c) threw away d) asked over
4. Americans _____ too much plastic. They should reuse, reduce, and recycle. a) give up b) get across c) throw away d) bring up

5. I don't want to _____ learning English! It's difficult, but I can do it! a) give up b) calm down c) put away d) put off
6. My essay was thorough because I didn't want to _____ any supporting points. a) fill in b) leave out c) figure out d) turn off
7. Aaron will be late to the meeting because he had to _____ his application at the front office. a) call off b) get across c) give back d) drop off
8. Muhamad didn't want to _____ his wife, so he rushed home after school. a) build up b) break down c) let down d) calm down
9. The CEO has a great vision for the company, but can she _____ all that she intends? a) carry out b) hang up c) leave out d) give out
10. I didn't realize I'd have to _____ the money that I received for financial aid. a) call back b) give out c) give back d) fill up

Exercise 8. Inseparable phrasal verbs: meaning in context. Choose the most appropriate phrasal verb.

1. The professor's lecture _____ the differences between the Christian denominations. a) carried on b) stood for c) touched on d) fell for
2. Penelope _____ her little sister. a) takes after b) looks after c) goes over d) follow through with
3. Daren _____ his dad's personality. a) takes after b) looks back on c) cashes in on d) sees about
4. Let's _____ the grammar rules one more time. a) get over b) carry on c) put up with d) go over
5. The letters used in algebra _____ numbers. a) carry on b) stand for c) get on d) watch out for
6. Before a plant _____ fruit, it must be pollenated. a) turns into b) takes after c) stands for d) looks after
7. He needs more time to _____ his writing assignments. a) look back on b) fall for c) turn into d) keep up with
8. Sometimes the person that _____ others has personal problems. a) picks on b) look back on c) get out of d) follow through with
9. The passenger wanted to _____ the bus, so he rang the bell. a) get together with b) put up with c) stand for d) get off
10. Instead of punishing a child for doing something wrong, _____ the consequences. a) see about b) talk over c) look after d) watch out for

Exercise 9. Which meaning? Choose the meaning from the list in Rules ("Phrasal verbs with multiple meanings"). The letters are the same as in the lesson material.

1. Billy works out at a gym, but I prefer to work out at home.
2. I didn't teach Hadi Arabic. He picked it up while listening to his cousins.
3. The job opportunity was just too good to turn down!
4. Owen made up a story so that he didn't get in trouble.
5. The economy is starting to pick up now that people are getting vaccinated.

6. The painting in the cave was so old, the archeologists couldn't make out the script.
7. After she transferred to Reedley College, things were looking up.
8. Before working on the pipe, please cut off the water.
9. If he mentions politics or religion, please cut him off.
10. I hope your passion never goes out.

More items: lesson material, Exercise 9 (items 11-20). Your tutor can check them.

Exercise 10. Phrasal verbs in "The Value of Confusion". Match each phrasal verb in bold to its meaning: a) discover b) handle c) quit d) consist of e) invent f) eventually in a situation you did not plan g) experiment with; test

1. ... it can be one of the most frustrating feelings to **deal with**.
2. ... people make educated guesses or **make up** an answer even if they know it isn't right.
3. Fighting confusion **ends up** making us more confused.
4. Identity is also **made up of** your values and goals.
5. People **figure out** their identity in two steps.
6. ... you **try out** different groups and values and see what fits.
7. Before you **give up**, make sure you have someone to help you ...

Speak with your tutor

- "Exercises 5 and 6: say a phrasal verb from the book's lists. I will give its meaning and a sentence. Then check my answers to Exercise 7 (inseparable phrasal verbs with a pronoun: falls for them)."
- "Chain story (Exercise 11): 'Yesterday began like any other day.' We take turns adding two sentences, each turn with a phrasal verb. Then correct my phrasal verbs."
- "Ask me about my study habits: What do you put off? How do you keep up with your classes? What do you do when you can't figure out a topic?"

Read aloud

In phrasal verbs like these, the small word (up, back, off) is usually stressed, especially at the end of a sentence.

1. Hyun-Ki gave it UP.
2. Wei forgot to give it BACK.
3. Please turn it OFF.
4. The teacher will not put UP with them.
5. Before you give UP, make sure you have someone to help you.

Writing task

A chain story on your own (Exercise 11). Write a story of 120 to 160 words that begins: "Yesterday began like any other day." It can be shocking, funny or embarrassing, but it should make

sense. Use at least six phrasal verbs: two separable ones with a pronoun object (picked it up), two inseparable ones (got over it), and one with more than one meaning. Use the simple past, and underline the phrasal verbs.

Checklist:

- Every pronoun object is between the verb and the small word (turned it off, NOT turned off it).
- My inseparable phrasal verbs stay together (looked after them).
- Each phrasal verb has the meaning I want (I checked the book's lists).
- Irregular past forms are correct: gave up, took off, broke down, made up.
- The story has a clear beginning, middle and end.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Phrasal Verbs (Structure), Lesson 18 (English with Jennifer): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hcOivE5XH3g
- English Phrasal Verbs for Everyday Life: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G2NwmcNKaHk
- An Introduction to Phrasal Verbs: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e7tZSwasnRo

Answer key

Exercise 3 (book): 1. give it back 2. ask him over 3. broke it down 4. Please fill it up (with coffee). 5. help them out 6. pick it up 7. take it off 8. called them back 9. hang it up (prematurely) 10. turn it off. (The book's key leaves out "with coffee" and "prematurely"; these words can stay.)

Exercise 4 (book): 1. c) called off 2. d) build up 3. a) fixed up 4. c) throw away 5. a) give up 6. b) leave out 7. d) drop off 8. c) let down 9. a) carry out 10. c) give back

Exercise 8 (book): 1. c) touched on 2. b) looks after 3. a) takes after 4. d) go over 5. b) stand for 6. a) turns into 7. d) keep up with 8. a) picks on 9. d) get off 10. b) talk over

Exercise 9 (book): 1. a) exercise 2. c) learn a new skill 3. b) reject an offer or request 4. a) invent 5. g) improve 6. a) be able to identify or see with great effort 7. b) improve 8. b) stop the supply of something 9. c) interrupt someone 10. b) stop burning

Notes for items 11-20 in the lesson material: in item 15, b) end in failure is as good as the book's a) (compare the book's example "Negotiations broke down"). In item 17, the answer is e) overwhelm something like a phone or email (the book's key says d; this is a mistake because Twitter is a website, not a person: it was suddenly full of messages).

Exercise 10 (book): 1. b) handle 2. e) invent 3. f) eventually in a situation you did not plan 4. d) consist of 5. a) discover 6. g) experiment with; test 7. c) quit

My notes